FREE GUIDE FOR JAMAICAN & DIASPORA SMES

The SME Bottleneck Checklist

10 manual tasks small businesses can automate this month, and how to work out what each one is really costing you.

10
common bottlenecks, with the signs to look for

1
worksheet to put a dollar figure on manual work

5
safeguards to put in place before you automate anything

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START HERE

How to use this checklist

Most small businesses don't lose money in one big way. They lose it a few hours at a time: a lead nobody called back, the same numbers typed into three places, a report someone rebuilds every Friday.

Those hours are easy to miss because they're spread across the week. This checklist helps you find them.

> **Takes 15 minutes.** Go through the 10 bottlenecks on the next pages. For each one:

Step	What to do
1. Tick	Tick the box if it happens in your business, even occasionally.
2. Estimate	Write down roughly how many staff hours it takes per week. A rough guess is fine.
3. Rate the pain	Low / Medium / High: how much does it cost you in lost leads, mistakes or frustration?
4. Pick 3	Copy your three biggest into the worksheet on page 6 to get an annual cost.

What "automate" means here

Automation doesn't have to mean replacing people or buying expensive software. Usually it means one of three things:

→ **Connect** tools you already use so data moves by itself instead of being re-typed.
→ **Trigger** the next step automatically (a reply, a reminder, an alert) so it doesn't depend on someone remembering.
→ **Assist** a person with AI (drafting, sorting, measuring, flagging) while that person still approves anything important.

THE CHECKLIST · PART 1

Leads, customers & admin

A · LEADS & CUSTOMERS

1 Slow follow-up on new enquiries

SIGNS
Enquiries come in through WhatsApp, Instagram, email and your website, and someone replies "when they get a chance". Some never get a reply.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
Every enquiry lands in one list, gets an instant acknowledgement, and the right person gets a reminder until it's handled.

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

2 Answering the same questions over and over

SIGNS
Staff type the same answers about prices, opening hours, availability and "how does it work" many times a day.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
An assistant trained on *your* information answers routine questions and hands anything unusual to a person.

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

3 Quotes that need a site visit or manual calculation

SIGNS
You drive out just to measure, or rebuild every quote by hand, before the customer has even decided to buy.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
Customers send photos or details and get a first estimate quickly. *Real example: a Montego Bay window fabricator now quotes from customer photos (measurement error 1.2–4.6 mm).*

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

B · DATA ENTRY & ADMIN

4 Typing the same data into several places

SIGNS
The same customer or order details go into a form, then a spreadsheet, then the accounting system, by hand.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
Enter it once and it flows to every system that needs it, with checks that catch errors.

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

5 Paper registers, forms and sign-off sheets

SIGNS
Attendance, inspections, approvals or notices live on paper and get typed up later, if at all.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
Capture it digitally at the source, even by voice, with approval steps built in. *Real example: a school replaced paper registers and fee tracking with a voice-driven system.*

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

THE CHECKLIST · PART 2

Payments, reporting, tools & costs

6 Chasing payments and sending reminders by hand

SIGNS
Someone checks who hasn't paid and messages each customer one by one. Overdue accounts slip through.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
Polite reminders go out on schedule and stop automatically once payment is recorded. You see who's overdue at a glance.

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

C · REPORTING & DISCONNECTED TOOLS

7 Rebuilding the same report every week or month

SIGNS
Someone exports from several systems, pastes into a spreadsheet and formats it, and it's out of date by the time anyone reads it.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
A dashboard or scheduled report that updates itself from the source data.

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

8 Sorting and routing requests by hand

SIGNS
Support emails, job requests or complaints sit in one inbox until someone reads each one and decides who should handle it.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
AI reads each request, works out what it's about and how urgent it is, and routes it to the right person. A human still reviews edge cases.

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

9 Someone has to keep watching something

SIGNS
Stock levels, food trays, equipment or queues only get attention when someone happens to notice, often after a customer complains.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
Cameras or sensors flag the problem early. *Real example: a multi-camera system that alerts staff before a food tray runs out.*

☐ Happens here Hrs/week _____ Pain: L / M / H

D · AI & SOFTWARE COSTS

10 Paying for tools that overlap

SIGNS
Several AI or software subscriptions, per seat and per month, that do similar things. Nobody's sure which ones are actually used.

WHAT AUTOMATION LOOKS LIKE
One workflow designed around the actual tasks. Repetitive, private, high-volume work can run on AI you host yourself, so the cost is predictable.

☐ Happens here $/month _____ Pain: L / M / H

BEFORE YOU AUTOMATE

5 safeguards that keep automation from backfiring

AI can speed up a workflow, and it can also speed up a mistake. Put these in place before anything goes live:

1. **Fix the process before you automate it.** Automating a messy process only makes the mess faster. Write the steps down first.
2. **Check what goes in.** Bad data in means bad results out, however good the AI is. Validate data when it enters the system, and make the system stop and alert someone when data is missing or wrong, instead of quietly guessing.
3. **Add approval points for decisions that matter.** Payments, prices, anything sent to customers and anything legal should be approved by a person before it goes out.
4. **Give every automation a human owner.** One named person knows how it works, gets the alerts and can switch it off.
5. **Test it, then start small.** Ask to see the test results before anything goes live. Automate one bottleneck, measure the hours saved, then expand.

> **A question to ask any provider (including me):** "How will I know when this is wrong?" If the answer is vague, the system isn't ready.

WORKSHEET

What are your top 3 bottlenecks costing?

Copy your three highest-pain items from the checklist. For hourly cost, use the hourly rate of the person who does the work (their wage plus overheads). Your own time counts too.

Bottleneck	Hours / week	× Hourly cost	× 52 weeks	= Annual cost
1.			× 52	
2.			× 52	
3.			× 52	
			Total annual cost of manual work	

Then add what you can't see on a timesheet

Hidden cost	Your estimate
Leads lost per month because of slow follow-up × average sale value	
Errors or rework per month (wrong orders, missed payments)	
Overlapping software subscriptions per month × 12	

Example: 6 hrs/week re-typing orders × $1,200/hr × 52 = **$374,400 a year**, before counting a single mistake. (Use your own currency and rates.)

NEXT STEP

Found a bottleneck?
Let's look at it together.

Book a free 10-minute bottleneck review. We'll go through your worksheet, pick the one bottleneck most worth fixing, and look at what fixing it would involve. No sales pitch, and we don't talk tools until we've found the problem.

1
Bring your top 3 bottlenecks from page 6

2
We pick the one with the best return

3
You leave with a clear next step, whether or not you work with me

Book your free review →

Scan the code or open:
calendar.app.google/ZnDpUcTS3TXqDv4d9

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10+ years in enterprise infrastructure (Digicel, Supreme Ventures, Kingston Public Hospital).
Every client build is tested before it ships.

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Everyday solutions to everyday problems.